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networked. Online designers began to create truly interactive persistent worlds for folks to inhabit and adventure in. By the late 1980s names such as *Ultima*, *Civilisation* and the *Quest* series established themselves as gaming franchises with massive fan bases.

Rising sun

Meanwhile, the console world saw the entry of Japanese manufacturers. The Nintendo Entertainment System (NES) with its 8-bit CPU dominated the console market with an irresistible array of games—*Zelda*, the *Megaman Series*, *Tetris*, and of course, *Mario*. NES is credited with being the most successful game system yet, its closest competitors being the Atari 2600 and the Nintendo Gameboy. By the 1980s, games featured 2D sprite graphics, MIDI level sound and multiplayer capabilities. Computer games were no longer meant only for geeks. Gamers had become respectable. Almost.

In the 1990s the first 16-bit console from Sega made dents in Nintendo's world domination, with the Sega Genesis. *Sonic the Hedgehog*, was Sega's answer to Mario. *Mortal Kombat*, a fighting game created a huge controversy because of the blood and gore it depicted, resulting in the industry appointing its own rating system. Consoles would go from 16 to 32-bit, CDs would replace

cartridges, and more powerful processors would bring better graphics, sound, and multiplayer capabilities.

Achtung!

The 1990s also saw the fading away of adventure and turn-based strategy games. Games that were too slow and required too much planning or thought didn't go down too well with lowered attention spans and twitch addicts. In 1991, a 3D action game from id software called *Wolfenstein* was released as a shareware. *Wolfenstein* was about hitting out at the Nazis; the action was frenetic, violent, and fun. The retail version sold over 2,50,000 copies. It kick started the FPS (First Person Shooter) genre, following it with 3D action games that have now turned into an industry of their own. With *Doom*, *Doom II*, *Quake*, *Quake II*, and *Quake III*, id single-handedly pushed the envelope in graphics and multiplayer, coining terms such as 'deathmatch' and 'ragging'.

Two other games would spawn another subgenre that flourishes to this day—Real Time Strategy (RTS). Westwood's *Command and Conquer* series and Will Wright's *Simcity* took RTS to new heights, and

spawned dozens of imitators. Blizzard revitalised the dying RPG genre with *Diablo*, a hack and slash action-RPG hybrid.

It's a party—everyone's invited

In 1993, *Doom* made multiplayer gaming possible, and thanks to a service called Kali, it turned the Internet into one big LAN party. *Doom* laid the groundwork for all that was to follow in multiplayer gaming. With the advent of the Internet, multiplayer and team play elements flourished in PC games, and the evolutionary path of most games has been steadily heading toward that direction in almost all genres. Almost all games today offer some sort of online or multiplayer feature. Multiplayer games increase the 'replayability' of a game because no two experiences can be the same. The interaction with humans brings in certain dynamics that a computer cannot offer, and probably never will.

The popularity of *Counter-Strike* speaks for itself. RPG games went back to their MUD roots with Massively Multiplayer Online Role Playing Games (MMORPGs). These are persistent virtual universes, where players can interact freely with other players, partner up, and live a fictional life. *Ultima*



Mortal Kombat

1992

Duke Nukem

1994



Quake

1996



Half-Life

1998



Unreal Tournament

Quake III

1999



Max Payne

2001